

Figure 1: The contact list in Empathy

of these reasons that it is possible for both GNOME and KDE to use the Telepathy framework on their respective desktops with different front-ends.

Enter Empathy!

On GNOME, Telepathy is used by the Empathy IM client. Empathy has a user interface based on Gossip. Empathy supports various protocols like XMPP, Google Talk, MSN, IRC, SIP, etc. Furthermore, Empathy can also use *libpurple* via Telepathy-haze and hence support all the protocols that Pidgin does.

Empathy was included as a part of GNOME from version 2.24. Hence it has been (or is about to be) adopted by some of the major distributions like Ubuntu and Fedora as their default IM client. Its inclusion in these distributions has meant replacing Pidgin, which has caused some controversy, as some people feel it is not mature enough. Though Empathy does require a little more polish, it brings with it a huge number of features that more than make up

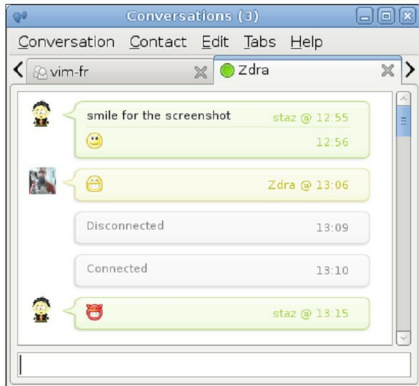


Figure 2: Conversation window with Adium chat themes

for its shortcomings. For example, if you have always drooled over how beautiful Adium looks, then you are in luck as Empathy supports Adium chat themes (and other themes as well), which really make the conversations look great.

Empathy was designed right from the beginning to have good VoIP/video chat features. Currently, video chat works only on XMPP and SIP, though hopefully, MSN and Google video chat should be supported for GNOME 2.28, in time.

Empathy supports video chat using open codecs like Theora and, therefore, should enable out-of-the-box video chat support, which could help us in ditching proprietary apps like Skype. Being able to have audio/video chats over popular protocols will certainly enable a smoother transition to Linux for many people and also improve the accessibility of the desktop.

Another cool feature that Empathy has is the sharing of geo-location information using the GeoClue project. This enables us to announce our current location and

we can, in turn, view the location of all our friends on a map. This is part of a bigger push on the Linux desktop to have geo-location support in as many apps as possible. Location information can range from something as specific as your street address to something much less accurate. The location is determined by using GPS, network information and other available sources that can be used by GeoClue. Unfortunately, this feature is only supported by XMPP servers that support PEP, and sadly, Google Talk doesn't.

A recently added feature to Empathy is the ability to share our desktop with our contacts. We have seen how elegantly this feature is implemented in iChat. A similar simplicity is employed here as well—you just select a contact with desktop sharing capability and that's about it! This is actually implemented using Telepathy's tubes feature that helps set up the connection and uses Vinagre for desktop sharing. This feature opens up a world of interesting applications. Imagine how useful this could be when you have to